

were embarrassed. First of all, our product was still buggy and low-quality. Second, although we were proud of our business results, they weren't exactly earth-shattering. The good news was that we were on a hockey-stick-shaped growth curve. The bad news was that the hockey stick went up to only about \$8,000 per month of revenue. These numbers were so low that we'd often have investors ask us, "What are the units on these charts? Are those numbers in thousands?" We'd have to reply, "No, sir, those are in ones."

However, those early results were extremely significant in predicting IMVU's future path. As you'll see in [Chapter 7](#), we were able to validate two of our leap-of-faith assumptions: IMVU was providing value for customers, and we had a working engine of growth. The gross numbers were small because we were selling the product to visionary early customers called early adopters. Before new products can be sold successfully to the mass market, they have to be sold to early adopters. These people are a special breed of customer. They accept—in fact prefer—an 80 percent solution; you don't need a perfect solution to capture their interest.⁴

Early technology adopters lined up around the block for Apple's original iPhone even though it lacked basic features such as copy and paste, 3G Internet speed, and support for corporate e-mail. Google's original search engine could answer queries about specialized topics such as Stanford University and the Linux operating system, but it would be years before it could "organize the world's information." However, this did not stop early adopters from singing its praises.

Early adopters use their imagination to fill in what a product is missing. They prefer that state of affairs, because what they care about above all is being the first to use or adopt a new product or technology. In consumer products, it's often the thrill of being the first one on the block to show off a new basketball shoe, music player, or cool phone. In enterprise products, it's often about gaining a competitive advantage by taking a risk with something new that competitors don't have yet. Early adopters are suspicious of something that is too polished: if it's ready for everyone to adopt,